

David Johnson

David Johnson adamantly describes himself as a "blind artist" rather than an artist who is blind. This nuanced distinction may be considered slight, or even insignificant, but for Johnson owning his blindness as an indelible part of his identity is a deliberate act of reclamation. "I regard blindness as a positive and integral part of the creating of my art and not something to be overcome or worked around as a barrier to creativity."...As he explores the relationship between preception and knowledge, his work leans toward those universal experiences that can be intensified by his blindness. In *Citrus Corners* (2012) four black, cone-shaped forms emerge from a flat, reflective black base made of Perspex. Each cone is topped with a bright, citrus-colored tip. Though hardened plaster, the shapes create the illusion of softness, giving a contradictory sensual experience. With the incomplete forms provided, we can only speculate on what lies beneath or the meaning of the work as presented. As Johnson extrapolates, "most of the meaning or significance that we give to the world is based on scraps of sensory evidence, evidence that is itself ambiguous." As a blind person, scraps of evidence gathered in day-to-day experiences are based upon one less sense, but associative memory and connection to abstract ideas are heightened.

—Timothy W. Hiles, *Art, Movement, and Disability: Transcending the Beauty Paradigm*, [New York: Routledge Press, 2026], p. 59-60.

I have a hereditary genetic disorder called retinitis pigmentosa which means over time my retina has degenerated. I originally went to art school as a painter, but retrained as a pianist, then a piano tuner, when it became clear I would lose my sight by mid-life. When I went totally blind in my mid-30s I got back into art through my children; discussing the art they made, feeling it and getting my head round it. I started going to audio described events at galleries where I discovered that with clever descriptions one can experience art in a vivid way. When I started making again, I veered more towards 3D making. I also studied philosophy through The Open University, and found that philosophical studies fell happily into the artwork I was making and vice versa.

—David Johnson

Transient Objects Caught in a Multi-Dimensional Moment of Impossible Pringles investigates the moment of touch in space-time between subject and object. Utilizing 3D print technology, the points of momentary contact between the hand or fingertips and an everyday object are isolated and 3D printed. This piece is concerned with trying to better understand what it is to touch. It is focusing on the transient nature of the tactile encounter. It also highlights the ambiguity of touch; the moment of touch is both of the body or the skin and of the object being touched. In recording this moment, one is recording a synthesis where two becomes one and when one is pluralised. They are quantum moments of spatio-temporality or synchronicity. This represents a ubiquitous experience in the blind-life world and thus is central to the blind aesthetic.